

THE UNIVERSITY OF CHICAGO
SOCIAL SCIENCES COLLEGIATE DIVISION
OFFICE OF THE MASTER

To: SOSC Core Chairs
From: Jenny Trinitapoli, Master Social Sciences Collegiate Division
Date: August 1, 2026
Re: Guidance on SOSC Core Pedagogy: AI and our teaching

This document articulates a consensus that has emerged among SOSC Core chairs over the past academic year in consultation with the following faculty: Anne Beal, Paul Cheney, Scott Cooley, Daragh Grant, Bobby Gullotty, Sarah Hammerschlag, Anne Henly, John Kelly, Sankar Muthu, James Sparrow, Jennifer Spruill, and Geoffrey Wodtke. It specifies a general approach to teaching and learning in the SOSC Core for AY 2027 and beyond. The positions articulated here are resonant with two insights from the [Artificial Intelligence and Education Working Group's report from 2025](#). The first emphasizes the centrality of human engagement, human interaction, and human expertise to UChicago's educational mission. That report also recommends clarity in teaching and learning with respect to the role of artificial intelligence (AI). It suggests that faculty and instructors use the terminology "with AI, without AI, and about AI" to designate and describe different modalities of teaching and learning. The strong consensus from the SOSC core is that our sequences are best understood as a pedagogical setting without AI.

SOSC sequences at the University of Chicago are connected by a shared trio of goals, summarized nicely by [Robert Redfield \[paraphrasing\]](#): communicating the historical development of contemporary society, conveying some understanding of the scientific spirit as applied to social problems, and cultivating within the student a capacity to address oneself in that spirit to such a problem. The shared objective of all eight sequences is a profoundly human one; at UChicago we train students to use both reason and specialized knowledge in preparation for life as a free person, as well as for further scholarly pursuit. Both pursuits require a confrontation with rapid social change in the global world of the 21st century, and AI is one such instance of rapid social change. Meant to lay the groundwork for higher level study at the College, in the SOSC Core we first equip students to read, write, and think without dependence on AI, just as we equip students to read, write, and think beyond the bounds of conventional views or leading ideologies.

Although practices have varied course-by-course in recent years, in AY 2027 sequences are collectively designed to be taught as "analog" courses. This means that students will read texts on paper and engage primarily through guided discussion, unmediated by devices. SOSC courses are offered as discussion-based sections in which attendance is mandatory. Details may vary by sequence and instructor. However, consistent with our shared learning objectives in SOSC sequences, it only makes sense for default policies and expectations to be shared as well.

What students can expect:

- syllabi designed by human scholars at the University of Chicago who have generated these materials as a team, refining them over a period of years – even decades.
- collectively taught courses that transcend the tastes of any particular instructor or trio of instructors.
- discussion-based engagement with faculty and fellow students.
- sustained conversation with peers over the course of a full year; the instructor may rotate quarter-to-quarter.
- small courses of <20 students, in which instructors assume full responsibility for the assessment and evaluation of student work. In the SOSC core, students can trust that grading of and feedback on assignments are not outsourced to TAs, interns, or LLMs.
- moderate reading loads with adequate guidance about how human students can successfully complete complex reading assignments.

The corresponding class policies can be briefly summarized as such:

- Class attendance in-person is required.
- Recording class discussion or lectures is prohibited.
- The classroom is a device-free space. Put away laptops and cell-phones. The use of wearable AI (such as Meta glasses) during class is also prohibited.
- Our focus will be on the course materials, discussion, and human interaction. Expect free, robust, and uninhibited discussion.
- Students are expected to complete all coursework independently, unassisted by AI, which we take to be a basic requirement of academic honesty in the SOSC Core.
- Reasonable academic accommodations that do not compromise course objectives or learning goals will be honored.

We fully expect that individual faculty members may carve out exceptions to the device-free norm for specific purposes. On a particular day, for example, students may be asked to bring laptops to collectively examine tabulations in a dataset, to troubleshoot code, to revise a page of text, or to access library website for guidance about citation practices and learn shortcuts. Generally speaking students can expect to keep laptops, tablets, and phones away in their bags, set to silent mode.

With respect to AI in the SOSC classroom, note that our consensus permits thoughtful experimentation. In order that the whole SOSC Core might benefit from the fruits of such experimentation, we ask that instructors communicate deviations from the general approach outlined here to the sequence chair and SSCD Master by the first day of class. As ever, course policies should be clearly described to students on syllabi. We remind instructors that we currently have no positive knowledge about the quality of AI-assisted grading (i.e., grading by Claude) in the social sciences. At this time, the SOSC chairs & SSCD Master agree that AI-assisted grading has no place in the SOSC Core unless faculty are carefully assessing its validity against human grading. In

any case, students can expect that if an instructor plans to experiment with AI grading in their SOSC course, this will be explicitly stated in the course syllabus.

To be clear: The twin decisions to put devices away and prioritize, instead, the cultivation of our own minds through discussion is not intended as a restriction -- nor is the guidance for SOSC Core a wholesale rejection of technology, which can be used for good scholarly purposes in other parts of the curriculum. In support of our learning objectives, these guidelines afford students the freedom to think for themselves, to listen to one another without the cacophony of other (disembodied and non-human) voices in the room, to make mistakes, and to change their minds as they engage with thinkers of the past, with us, and with their fellow students in good faith, face-to-face.